

Yuxi Zhong (Sonam Dorji)

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🎓 EDUCATION

Northeastern University , Shenyang, China	09/2022 – 06/2025
M.A. Art Theory	GPA: 3.90/4.0
Sichuan Agricultural University , Chengdu, China	09/2018 – 06/2022
B.A. Politics and Public Administration	GPA: 3.57/4.0

📄 PUBLICATION

Journal Articles

- Zhong, Yuxi. 2025. “When a Cat Becomes a God” (Under review)
- Zhong, Yuxi, and Zhang Yannan. 2023. “The Aesthetic Connotation of the Word ‘乐’ and Its Direction Towards Aesthetic Development.” *China National Exhibition* 24, 232-234. [In Chinese]

Conference Paper

Zhong, Yuxi. “The Death of the Rat: Memory and Identity of Cat-Worship Culture in Xiangcheng.” “Mountains and Seas” Ethnology Graduate Student Forum, April 26-27, 2025.

🔍 RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

The Dialogue between “Om” and “Xiang”: Art, Memory, and Identity in Xiangcheng Stove Cults

M.A. Thesis, Independent Researcher 10/2023 – 6/2025

- Designed and executed a nine-month ethnographic fieldwork study, employing participant observation, in-depth interviews (n=100+), and visual/material analysis (700+ photographs), supplemented by statistical survey analysis (SPSS, NVivo).
- Proposed a “Nehulay-to-Stove Cat” transformation model, arguing that the local cat-worship phenomenon is a “carnavalesque resistance” that deconstructs the orthodox power discourse of Tibetan Buddhism. Demonstrated how stove art functions as a crucial medium for reshaping social memory and constructing local ethnic identity in the face of cultural modernization.

Motifs of Change: Material Culture and Economy in Tibetan Rug Production

Team Leader 06/2020 – 08/2020

- Led a fieldwork team investigating the material culture and symbolic economy of animal imagery in Tibetan rug production.
- Combined a month of fieldwork with quantitative analysis of motif frequencies and artisan surveys to investigate the socio-political symbolism of animal imagery in Tibetan rugs, culminating in a 10,000+ word report.

Grassroots Governance and Community Dynamics in Urban China

Core Research Team Member

11/2019 – 02/2021

- Designed and executed a mixed-methods study on community governance across 7 award-winning urban communities in Chengdu. Employed quantitative (136 valid questionnaires) and qualitative (50+ structured interviews) approaches to analyze the mechanisms of resident participation and service delivery.
- Developed a “One Core, Two Networks, Three Guarantees” governance framework, which was later adopted by three communities to guide their policy and practice. This research formed the basis of my B.A. thesis, which focused specifically on the role of resident participation.

Visual Culture and Material Memory in Chinese Revolutionary Heritage Sites

Core Research Team Member

11/2018 – 06/2019

- Participated in a two-year mixed-methods study on revolutionary heritage in the Sichuan-Shaanxi region, analyzing the visual and material strategies of public memorialization through comparative analysis, extensive interviews, and surveys across three cities (N=182, analyzed with SPSS).
- Co-authored a comprehensive research report with policy recommendations, which was officially adopted by three county-level cultural and tourism bureaus.

ACADEMIC PROJECTS

Embodied Knowledge and Cultural Transmission in Traditional Puppetry

Participant-Researcher

06/2023 – 09/2023

Investigated the role of traditional puppetry in preserving intangible cultural heritage and constructing community identity. Conducted a three-month fieldwork, employing participant observation by training and performing as a member of a local troupe. Analyzed the transmission of embodied, non-textual artistic knowledge and the function of performance as a medium for social cohesion.

Ecologies of Heritage: Cultural Revitalization in Rural China

Team Leader

11/2022 – 10/2023

Conducted fieldwork on Bashao Island, specifically studying the customs and intangible cultural heritage of the islanders. Explored the connection between the community and the cultural ecosystem. Suggested a culturally sensitive framework for conserving and rejuvenating rural Chinese culture and folk traditions, showcasing the island's significance as a model.

From Ritual Governance to Aesthetic Transcendence: A Semiotic Genealogy of “乐”

Independent Researcher

11/2022 – 03/2023

Conducted a diachronic semiotic analysis of the polyphonic character “Lè/Yuè” (乐), mapping its trajectory across three dimensions. Investigated how the signifier evolved from ritual-political statecraft (Yuè) to secular embodied affect (Lè), and ultimately to cosmological transcendence. Drawing on historical aesthetics and textual analysis, argued this linguistic bifurcation indexes a transformation in Chinese subjectivity: moving from collective normative ordering toward a metaphysics of aesthetic liberation.

✿ OTHER EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant, Prof. Yannan Zhang, Northeastern University 2025 – Present
Analyzed survey data (N>500) with SPSS, assisted in 30+ interviews and experiments, and authored multiple literature reviews using a 500+ article bibliography managed in Zotero.

Animal Protection Advocacy and Leadership 2018 – Present
Orchestrated animal welfare initiatives facilitating the rehabilitation and rehoming of 300+ animals; spearheaded the association's public relations strategy and digital presence; and curated 21 community advocacy events. Selected as the regional delegate for Southwest China at the Beijing Animal Protection Training Camp.

Peking Opera Study and Performance 2018 – 2022
Trained in Peking Opera performance and aesthetics; staged three shows and competed in a national collegiate opera competition.

🏆 HONOURS AND AWARDS

Outstanding Graduation Dissertation (Pending), <i>NEU</i>	2025
China Int'l College Students' Innovation Comp, <i>Nat'l Bronze Award</i>	2024
Second-class Academic Scholarship, <i>NEU</i>	2023
Outstanding Individual in Social Practice, <i>NEU</i>	2023
China Int'l College Students' Innovation Comp, <i>Provincial Gold Award</i>	2023
Rank 1st in Graduate Entrance Examination (Written & Interview)	2022
First-class Academic Scholarship, <i>NEU</i>	2022&2023
Outstanding President of the University Association, <i>SICAU</i>	2020
Outstanding Individual in Summer Vacation Social Research, <i>SICAU</i>	2020
Outstanding Individual in Winter Vacation Social Research, <i>SICAU</i>	2019&2020&2021
Sichuan Agricultural University Sports Competition, <i>First Prize</i>	2019
"Challenge Cup" Nat'l College Student Business Plan Comp, <i>Provincial Bronze Award</i>	2019

👤 PROFESSIONAL AFFILIATION

Member, China Society for Anthropology of Arts	04/2024 – Present
President, Association for the Protection of Animals (<i>SICAU</i>)	03/2019 – 12/2020
Standing Committee Member, Public Welfare Associations (<i>SICAU</i>)	09/2019 – 09/2020

✂ SKILLS

Technical Skills | NVivo, SPSS, ZOTERO, VOSviewer, Adobe (PS, LR, PR), Shapr3D
Languages | Mandarin (Native), Sichuan dialect (Native, primary language of my proposed field site), English (Fluent), Classical Chinese (Proficient in reading), Tibetan (Basic)